

Obama for Consumer Protection

As part of Barack Obama's plans for revitalising the economy, the White House has announced plans for a new state sponsored agency called Consumer Protection Financial Agency which will deal with mortgages and credit cards among other things

Digit asks, HP responds...

Many readers have written to us complaining of repeated problems with HP laptops, particularly those with NVIDIA chips overheating. We first contacted HP about these problems at the end of March, and the company has recently responded, endeavouring to determine just what has been going on, and to help solve our readers' problems.

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It came to us as quite a surprise, after asking readers to write in with service problems to find that nearly half of those that arrived concerned HP laptops. As I wrote at the time, in our May issue: "So, is this a statistical cluster, or does HP really have a problem?" The answer seems to lie midway between the two. Statistically, we are likely to see a fair number of problems with HP simply because of the company's large market share and the sheer size of the operation. Problems are bound to occur.

In the top seven cities in India, according to HP's figures, the company's market share of laptops is 61-62 per cent, with a national average of 54 per cent. This means that the company is shipping between 65 and 70 thousand units per month. These are serviced through over 350 service points across the company. Things are bound to go wrong, and HP has told me that each month a handful do experience serious problems.

But not all problems are genuine, and clearly any company like HP will need to distinguish between genuine and invalid problems. I was told that it was not possible to formulate an unambiguous policy to cater for all instances and problems. For example, somebody in the channel might drop a unit, it then gets passed onto the customer, who tries to get a fix from HP. One user had the strap break on his laptop

case after just a few days over ownership, and the laptop crashed to the ground - should HP replace the laptop?

HP told me that checks and balances are in place, but sometimes these go overboard, and a user with a genuine problem finds it difficult to get a proper response. So, what if a user has a genuine problem, and does not get an appropriate response from HP? We have two readers whose motherboards have been replaced or repaired eight times - surely, once two or three repeat repairs have been done, a different approach should be taken?

HP told me of the "escalation channel" to use in such an instance. Looking at the huge HP web site, it is not clear what process is intended by this. HP

has told me that there are three ways in which a user can access this channel:

On the website, go to the page entitled "Register a Complaint" - this page is not easy to find. Searching on those words does not locate the page.

The cause of the problems?

Given that most of the problems our readers have reported entail repeated failure due to overheating, it is natural to consider the problems that arose a year or so back with NVIDIA chips, particularly the GeForce 8x and 9x series. These contained a manufacturing flaw that did cause overheating - reported in laptops from HP, Dell and Apple. However, this was some time ago, and according to NVIDIA, the problem was fixed "two generations [of chips] ago". Also, HP has assured me that none of these chips made their way into the Indian market, but were restricted to the north American market. Some may have been grey imports, of course, but the company has told me that all HP laptops for sale in India are made in China, and there were no shipments of the faulty NVIDIA chipsets there.

And yet our readers laptops are still overheating. What is going on? HP operates a process called "unit capture" when there is a persistent and repeating problem. A user is given a replacement machine, and their own laptop is sent over to HP in Cupertino, California, in order to diagnose what has been going wrong.

Of our two readers whose

motherboards have been repaired eight times, Manoj Nair's laptop has been repaired and returned to him. He has told me that his laptop is, for now, working fine. Mridhul Sanjeev has been given a replacement laptop, and his own one has been sent to Cupertino for analysis. Hopefully, we will have an answer soon.

Warranty

Of the cases that we had passed on from readers to HP, a few were in fact outside of warranty. The standard warranty is for one year. However, a user can purchase an HP "Care Pack" which effectively extends the warranty by up to three years. There are many different levels of service that you can pay for: whether you want a six-hour call out, or will next day do, whether you would need a replacement machine while yours is being fixed, etc.

We have mentioned the fact that checks and balances are in place to determine whether a complaint is genuine or not, and one aspect of this is whether the machine is still under warranty. HP explained that the end of warranty is very much an on/off type of thing; there is no good calling HP, or any other company for that matter, and pleading: "It's just one week after the end of warranty." That simply will not work.

So, make sure that all your paperwork is in order when you purchase a machine or other product, check the date on the bill, and fill in and post off any registration forms that are required, making a copy of them first, if possible.

V3000 advisory

The advisory apparently mentioned by HP service staff to Manoj Nair, is called "HP Pavilion dv2000/dv6000 and Compaq Presario v3000/v6000 Series Notebook PCs - HP Limited Warranty Service Enhancement". This advisory certainly exists on the HP web site, but it is very difficult to find. I needed help - a direct link - from HP to access, and so how a user will come across it when they might not even know it exists, is beyond me. The advisory mentions the availability of extended warranty for these models, and also a BIOS upgrade, and describes problems such as failure of the WiFi adapter to work, lack of video display and failure of the laptop to start. But there is no mention of the overheating problem at all.